GEMS OF INDIA

SAVIOUR OF OUR RICE DIVERSITY

Basudha's yeoman service in preserving traditional rice varieties has not just preserved forgotten seeds but also created a grassroots network of biodiversity custodians

By **ARKAMOY DATTA MAJUMDAR**



SEEDING THE FUTURE Basudha founder Debal Deb with young farmers and researchers

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A dedicated ecological farm and conservation initiative, Basudha functions as a trust under the Centre for Interdisciplinary Studies (CIS), an umbrella organisation working on preserving traditional crop diversity, especially for India's indigenous rice varieties. Basudha ('Earth Mother' in Bengali) now works out of a 1.7-acre farm in a tribal village in the Bissam Cuttack area of Rayagada district in southern Odisha, where farmers and researchers gather and learn about traditional agricultural practices, organic farming and ecological architecture.

At the heart of its work is the collection and regeneration of indigenous rice varieties. Founder and conservation scientist Debal Deb says over the past many years, he has collected 1,480 varieties of rice, of which some 800 varieties are preserved only on Basudha's farm or in national/international gene banks. Another 180 'rarest' varieties are not known to exist anywhere outside Basudha's farm. To maintain genetic integrity and purity, the centre verifies 56 phenotypic features in each rice variety every year. Deb points out that till the 1970s, the Indian subcontinent hosted an estimated 110,000 distinct varieties of rice. Decades of industrial hybrid seed adoption and modern crop practices have dramatically

WHY IT IS A GEM

- **Basudha founder Debal Deb has collected 1,480 varieties of traditional rice; only he has 180 'rarest' ones**
- **17,000 farmers in 8 states have got seeds from Basudha; 20,000 more now cultivate these grains**
- **To maintain genetic purity, the centre verifies 56 phenotypic features in each rice variety every year**